

Session 17: Abraham Intercedes for Lot

Key Takeaways

- When Yahweh enlists a covenant partner, he consistently chooses to limit himself to act in and through his covenant partners.
- Sodom and Gomorrah are described with vocabulary from all the previous stories of violence and injustice, and they become emblematic of these themes throughout the rest of the Bible.
- Avraham assumes that God doesn't share his concern for justice, but he misunderstands God's judgment and underestimates God's mercy.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 18:16-22

- a 16 **And the men arose from there,**
b **and they looked down upon Sodom.**
c **Now, Avraham was going with them, to send them off,**

17 **and Yahweh said,**

"Should I hide from Avraham **what I am about to do**?

18 For Avraham will certainly become **a nation great** and powerful,
and **all nations** of the land will discover **blessing** through him;

19 Indeed, **I have known** him,

so that he would command his sons and his house after him,

that they should **keep the way of Yahweh,**

by **doing what is right and just**

so that Yahweh will bring upon Avraham what he has spoken about him."

20 **And Yahweh said,**

"**The outcry (זעקה)** against Sodom and Gomorrah, it is huge,
and their failure, it is heavy, very much.

21 I should go down,

so I can see if **the outcry (זעקה)** that has come before me,

is **what they have completely done**,

and if not, then **I will know**."

- a 22 **And the men turned from there,**
b **and they went to Sodom.**

Genesis 18:16-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avraham, the Noah-Like Remnant

God's internal speech in [Genesis 18:17-21](#) is similar to the divine speeches of [Genesis 6:5-7](#) and [Genesis 11:5-7](#), where God deliberates about what he should do given the outbreak of human violence ruining the land.

Notice how in [Genesis 18:22](#), we're told Avraham is standing right next to Yahweh as Yahweh talks to himself. Even though Yahweh is "asking" himself the question, it seems obvious that he wants to include Avraham in the conversation, which is what happens when he speaks up in [Genesis 18:23](#).

Genesis 6:8-9 NASB

⁸ But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD. ⁹ These are the records of the generations of Noah. Noah was **righteous, blameless** in his generation; Noah **walked with God**.

Genesis 7:1 NASB

Then the LORD said to Noah, "Enter the ark, you and all **your house**, for you alone I have seen to be **righteous before me** in this generation."

Genesis 15:6 NASB

Then he believed in the LORD; and he reckoned it to him as **righteousness**.

Genesis 17:1 NASB

Now when Abram was ninety-nine years old, the LORD appeared to Abram and said to him, "I am God Almighty; **walk before me**, and be **blameless**."

Genesis 18:19 NASB

I have known him, so that he would command his sons and **his house** after him, that they should keep the way of the LORD, by doing **righteousness** and justice, so that the LORD may bring upon Abraham what he has spoken about him.

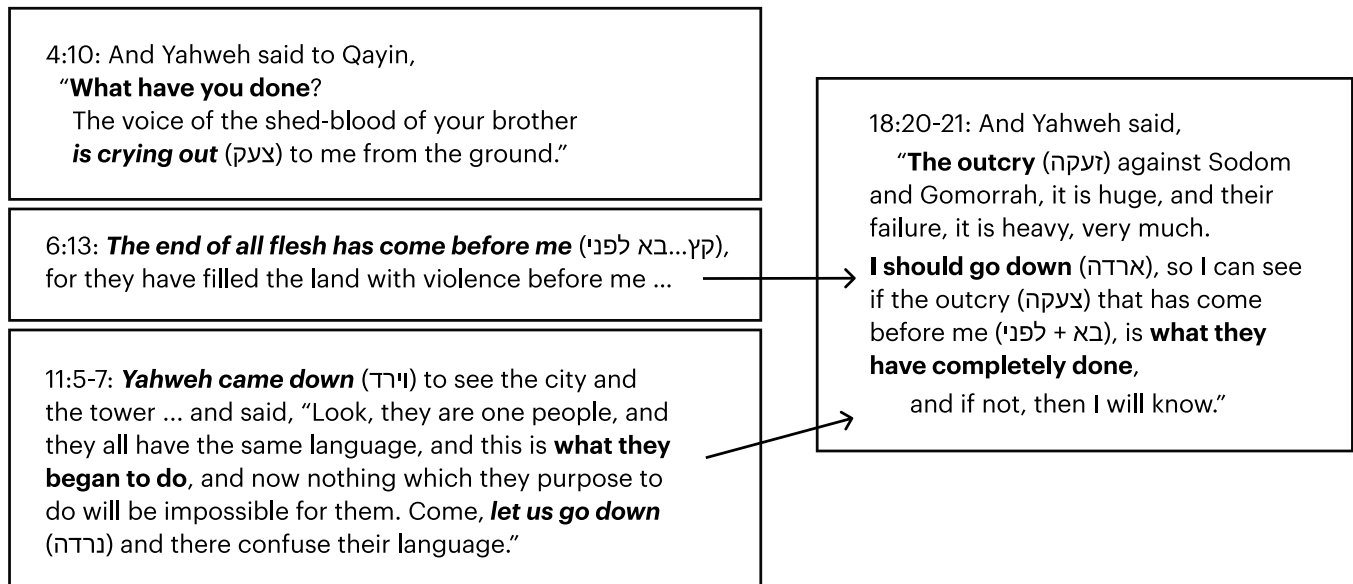
God chose Noah and spared his family because of Noah's righteousness ([Gen. 6:8-9](#); [7:1](#)). Also, it was after Noah's deliverance that he made a going-up offering that atoned for humanity's evil and compelled God to bring about a new creation ([Gen. 8:20-22](#)). So now God includes Avraham, who is also righteous before God ([15:6](#)). However, different from Noah, Avraham must speak up and ask for his family (i.e., Lot and his family) to be spared from the ruin of Sodom.

Sodom, Cain, the Flood, and Babylon

This introduction to the Sodom story begins with a combination of motifs that are gathered from previous stories in the same thematic slot: the moment that human evil begins to increase so much that Yahweh

cannot ignore it.

Yahweh's words, spoken to himself (just like in [Gen. 6:5](#) and [Gen. 11:6-7](#)), use all the key words from the divine speeches about Cain's murder, the violence before the flood, and the building of the city and tower of Babylon.



Sodom, Qayin, the Flood, and Babylon. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The result of these analogies is that Sodom and Gomorrah become an amalgamation of Cain's city of blood, the generation of the flood, and the hubris of Babylon. It's an icon of the human city of idolatry and violence, where the innocent suffer and cry out to God.

Ezekiel's portrait of Sodom seems to be based on this entire network of analogies, not just the story in [Genesis 19](#).

Ezekiel 16:48-50 ESV*

⁴⁸As I live, declares the Lord God, your sister Sodom and her daughters have not done as you and your daughters have done. ⁴⁹Behold, this was the guilt of your sister Sodom: she and her daughters had **pride**, they were **overfilled with food**, and **calm ease**, but **did not strengthen the hand of the poor and needy**. ⁵⁰They were **haughty** and did an abomination before me. So I removed them, when I saw it.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Avraham's Justice and Righteousness

Yahweh's speech ([Gen. 18:17-19](#)) about Avraham (which he apparently says out loud, standing next to him!) is revealing, and gives the reader new, developed insight into God's purpose in selecting Avraham.

17 **and Yahweh said,**

“Should I hide from Avraham **what I am about to do** ?

18 For Avraham will certainly become **a nation great** and powerful,
and **all nations** of the land will discover **blessing** through him;

19 Indeed, **I have known** him,

so that he would command his sons and his house after him,

that they should **keep the way of Yahweh,**

by **doing what is right and just**

so that Yahweh will bring upon Avraham what he has spoken about him.”

Genesis 18:16-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Yahweh is not hiding the divine purpose from Avraham, even as he asks the question. He clearly means to include Avraham in the deliberations of the divine purpose, and so Avraham becomes here a true “image of God,” a human who’s invited into the divine council and who can influence Yahweh’s governance of the cosmos.

Yahweh refers back to his words in Genesis 12:3 where he chose Avraham and his family to become a conduit of divine blessing to the nations. This very story gives a concrete application of what that vocation truly entails. Avraham will stand before Yahweh and intercede on behalf of the innocent.

The Hebrew syntax of Genesis 18:19 is intentionally complex, revealing God’s dual purpose.

God chose Avraham in order to create a family that lives in alignment with the will of God, referred to by two descriptions: “the way of Yahweh” and “doing righteousness and justice.” Both of these phrases are introduced here for the first time in the Hebrew Bible, and will go on to become significant themes throughout the biblical story.

God chose Avraham’s family to do what is right so that God can fulfill his promise to Avraham, which links back up to God’s quotation of his own promise in Genesis 12:3.

The fulfillment of God’s promise to Avraham is conditional upon the faithful obedience of Avraham’s family. But, as Avraham himself has already started to show, that condition is going to create serious problems, both for Avraham’s family and for God too!

The selection of Avraham “to do justice and righteousness” (Gen. 18:19) gives us categories for what Avraham is about to do, which is demand that God operate according to his own “way” by doing what is right and just in his dealings with Sodom and Gomorrah.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 18:23-33

23 **And Avraham drew near, and he said,**

a “Are you really about to **sweep away** the **righteous** along with the **wicked** ?

- b What if there are **fifty righteous people** in the middle of the city ?
- a' Would you really **sweep away** ?
- b' **Wouldn't you forgive** that place, on account of the **fifty righteous** which are **within it** ?
- a 25 **Far be it from you** to do such a thing,
- b to put to death the **righteous** along with the **wicked** ,
- b' so that the **righteous** and **wicked** become alike!
- a' **Far be it from you!**
- c Shouldn't the **justice-bringer** of all the land do **justice** ?
- 26 **And Yahweh said,**
 "If I find in Sodom **fifty righteous** ones **in the middle of the city** ,
 then **I will forgive** the entire place on account of them .

27 **And Avraham answered and said,**

- A " **Look, please, I have attempted to speak to my master,**
 and I am but dust and ashes.
- B 28 Perhaps that **fifty righteous** lacks **five**,
 would you **cause the ruin** of **the entire city because of those five**?
- C And he said,
 " **I would not cause ruin** if I find there **forty five**."

- A 29 **And he further spoken again to him, and said,**
- B "Perhaps there are found there **forty**."
- C And he said,
 " **I would not do it** on account of **forty**."

- A 30 **And he said,**
 " **Please don't let my master burn with anger, as I speak.**
- B Perhaps there are found there **thirty**."
- C And he said,
 " **I would not do it** if I find there **thirty**."

- A 31 **And he said,**
 " **Look, please, I have attempted to speak to my master,**
- B but perhaps there are found there **twenty**."
- C **And he said,**
 " **I would not cause ruin** on account of the **twenty**."

- A 32 **And he said,**
 " **Please don't let my master burn with anger, as I speak, just this time.**
- B Perhaps there are found there **ten**."
- And he said,**

“I would not cause ruin on account of the ten.”

³³ And Yahweh went away,
when he finished speaking to Avraham,
and Avraham, he returned to his place.

Genesis 18:16-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Does Avraham Haggle With God?

This story is cleverly designed to subvert the reader's expectations, and a second, more careful reading overturns a number of impressions made upon a first reading.

On a first reading, God announces that he is going to destroy Sodom and Gomorrah. Avraham knows that his nephew lives there, presumably with many other righteous folks, and he's afraid Yahweh's judgment will be too sweeping. So Avraham "haggles" with God, bargaining him down to a lower number of righteous people. Yahweh agrees, but on this interpretation Avraham becomes Yahweh's teacher.

There are problems with this interpretation. Avraham sets up the conversation as a bartering exchange, but Yahweh's responses subvert Avraham's assumptions.

- Avraham presents himself as "the buyer," starting at a low number, expecting that God would raise the numbers, so they can meet in the middle, say, 105.
- God unhesitatingly responds "yes" to every number Avraham proposes. This is not how you barter!

Avraham is the one who stops at 10 people, and he's the one who stops the conversation. [Genesis 18:33](#) does say that "Yahweh finished speaking to Avraham," but this is God's response to Avraham saying "one last time" (אך הפעם), before asking for 10. God follows Avraham's lead here.

"To the question, then, of whether there is haggling in Genesis 18, one might, perhaps, say yes, but haggling seems to be the intention of only one of the participants. ... It is [Avraham's] language that is extravagant; he is the one who requires Yhwh's justice to be quantifiable ... On the other hand, Yhwh refuses to participate in this game. Yhwh uses simple language and acquiesces in a straightforward manner. To every bid that Abraham makes there is only a divine yes and never a no. ... [So then] it might be better to speak of Yhwh's subversion of the pattern of haggling. Yhwh's opening speech (18:17-19), in which he emphasizes that he will not hide from Abraham his intent toward Sodom and Gomorrah ... Abraham, however, acts as though this significant move has not been taken. He continues to work within parameters that are obsolete, and it is perhaps this confusion that leads him to conclude at the perplexing figure of ten. If one were to search for a parallel other than haggling, comparison might be made to a child persistently testing parental boundaries, whether real or imagined."

MacDonald, Nathan (2004). "Listening to Abraham, Listening to Yhwh: Divine Justice and Mercy in Genesis 18:16-33." *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* (vol. 66). 40-41.

On a second, more careful reading, God invites Abraham into the divine council to begin teaching him “the way of Yahweh,” which means “doing justice and righteousness.” Abraham is unacquainted with Yahweh’s way and so assumes he has to haggle mercy out of Yahweh. Then, Yahweh subverts Abraham’s assumption in an attempt to teach him how to be a faithful partner, and Abraham only partially succeeds, stopping with the number 10.

Righteousness, Justice, and the Way of the Lord

There is an important contrast between what Yahweh says about his calling of Abraham, and what Abraham assumes about Yahweh’s character.

This is what Yahweh says about his “way.”

Genesis 18:19 Instructor’s Translation

Indeed, I have known him, **so that he would** command his sons and his house after him, that they should **keep the way of Yahweh**, by **doing righteousness and justice so that Yahweh will** bring upon Abraham what he has spoken about him.

This is what Abraham assumes about Yahweh’s “way.”

Genesis 18:25 Instructor’s Translation

Far be it from you to do such a thing, to put to death the **righteous** along with the wicked, so that the **righteous** and wicked become alike! **Far be it from you!** Shouldn’t the **justice-bringer** of all the land do **justice**?

The phrase “do righteousness and justice” is an idiom used to describe the actions of a leader done on behalf of his people to confront the forces of injustice and inequity, to deliver the poor and vulnerable in order to improve their quality of life. It is often synonymous with “mercy.”

2 Samuel 8:15 NASB

So David reigned over all Israel; and David **did justice and righteousness** for all his people.

Isaiah 9:6-7 NASB

⁶For a child will be born to us, a son will be given to us, and the government will rest on his shoulders; and his name will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Eternal Father, Prince of Peace. ⁷ ... On the throne of David and over his kingdom, to establish it and to uphold it **with justice and righteousness** from then on and forevermore.

Jeremiah 22:3 NASB

Thus says the LORD, "**Do justice and righteousness**, and deliver the one who has been robbed from the power of his oppressor. Also do not mistreat or do violence to the stranger, the orphan, or the widow; and do not shed innocent blood in this place."

Jeremiah 22:15-16 NIV*

¹⁵ “Does it make you a king to have more and more cedar? Did not your father have food and drink? He **did righteousness and justice**, so all went well with him. ¹⁶ He defended the cause of the poor and needy, and so all went well. Is that not what it means to know me?” declares the LORD.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 18:5-8 NIV*

⁵ Suppose there is a righteous man who **does justice and righteousness** ... ⁷ He does not oppress anyone, but returns what he took in pledge for a loan. He does not commit robbery but gives his food to the hungry and provides clothing for the naked. ⁸ He does not lend to them at interest or take a profit from them.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

For more examples of people doing this for other people, see: [1 Kings 10:9](#); [Isaiah 32:16-18](#), [58:24](#); [Jeremiah 23:5](#), [33:15](#); [Amos 5:10-12](#), [24](#); [Psalm 72:2-4](#).

If the above is what it means for humans to do justice and righteousness, what does it mean to say that righteousness and justice characterize “the way of Yahweh” ([Genesis 18:19](#))?

Psalms 103:6-12 NIV

- ⁶ The LORD **works righteousness and justice** for all the oppressed.
⁷ He made known his ways to Moses, his deeds to the people of Israel:
⁸ The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in love.
⁹ He will not always accuse, nor will he harbor his anger forever;
¹⁰ he does not treat us as our sins deserve or repay us according to our iniquities.
¹¹ For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his love for those who fear him;
¹² as far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us.

The “ways of Yahweh” here are linked to not only righteousness and justice for the vulnerable but also to compassion, mercy, and patience that are displayed in forgiving people and not treating them as their sins deserve.

[Psalm 103](#) is packed with hyperlinks to the golden calf narrative, where Moses ascends Mount Sinai to intercede for Israel in much the same way that Abraham does for Sodom. But Moses does not barter; he is much more bold as he asks for Yahweh’s mercy. In contrast, Abraham asks Yahweh a different question.

The phrase “to judge” and “justice” ([שפט/משפט](#)) can also be combined into “to judge with justice,” an idiom that primarily refers to judicial procedure and reward or punishment.

Deuteronomy 16:18 NASB

¹⁸ You shall appoint for yourself judges and officers in all your towns which the LORD your God is giving you, according to your tribes, and they shall **judge** the people with **righteous judgment**.

Ezekiel 18:8 NIV*

He withholds his hand from doing wrong and he **does justice** truthfully between people.

Isaiah 1:17 NASB

Learn to **do** good; seek **justice**, reprove the ruthless, defend the orphan, plead for the widow.

The phrase "do justice" or "judge with justice" adopts a courtroom framework and assumes the judge is fair, which means the results could go two ways.

The results may be positive.

Psalms 9:4 Instructor's Translation

For you have **done justice** for me and for my cause, you have sat on the throne **judging with righteousness**.

Psalms 140:12 Instructor's Translation

Know that Yahweh acts for the cause of the afflicted, **doing justice** for the poor.

The results may be negative and result in punishment.

Exodus 12:12 NASB*

For I will go through the land of Egypt on that night, and will strike down all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, both man and beast; and against all the gods of Egypt **I will do justice**—I am the LORD.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 5:8 NASB*

therefore, thus says the Lord God, "Behold, I, even I, am against you, and **I will do justice** among you in the sight of the nations."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 9:16 Instructor's Translation

Yahweh is known as one who **does justice**, by the work of his hands the wicked are trapped ...

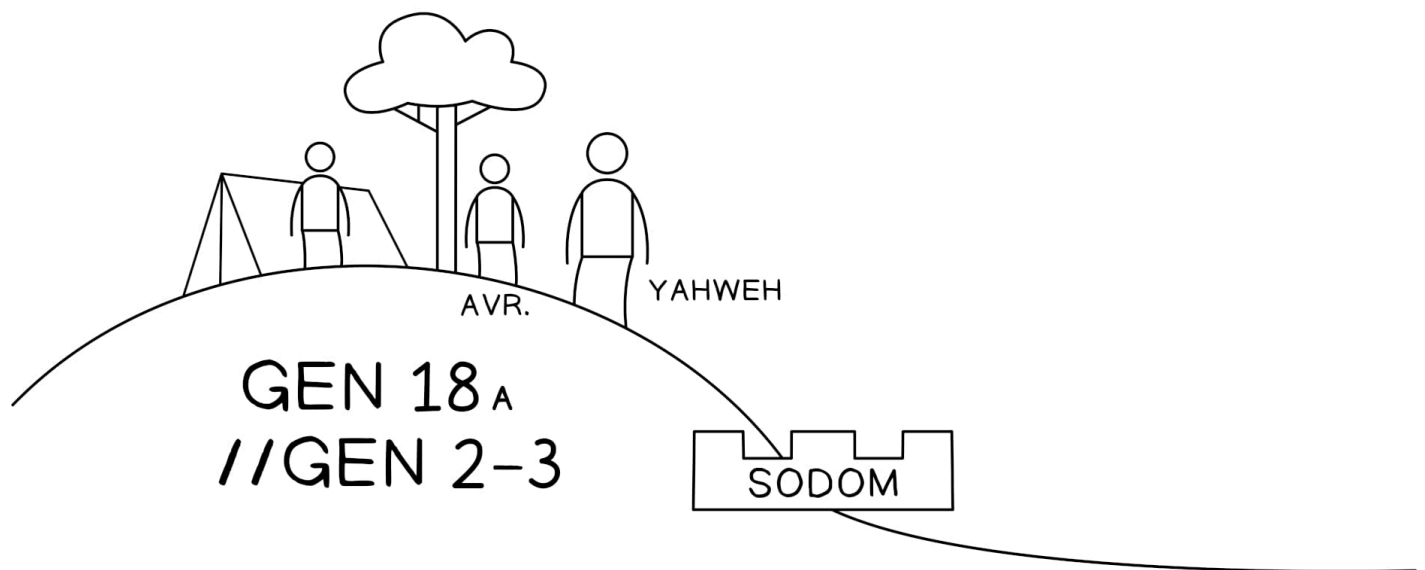
"The dialogue begins with Yhwh's indication that he is about to go down to discover the truth about Sodom's deeds. Punishment is by no means certain, but it is a distinct possibility. Abraham is given the opportunity to intercede for the city; he is treated as Yhwh's partner and told of Yhwh's plans, and he is then allowed to make his own contribution. Unlike Moses, Amos, and the other prophets, however, Abraham does not appeal to the mercy of God and ask for full forgiveness; instead, presuming Yhwh to be a harsh judge, he prepares to barter with him. His strategy is undone by Yhwh's persistent acceptance of Abraham's offer; Yhwh turns out to be far more merciful than Abraham imagines. Drawing the line at ten indicates not only the depth of Sodom's sin but also that Abraham has not plumbed the depths of Yhwh's grace ... Yhwh has become Abraham's teacher, and the dialogue at Mamre is an important moment in the moral education of Abraham. It is the moment when Yhwh seeks to instruct Abraham about 'his way,' and the dialogue is an interactive lesson in which Abraham learns the extent of Yhwh's mercy toward his creation, so that Abraham and his descendants may follow in that same way."

MacDonald, Nathan (2004). "Listening to Abraham, Listening to Yhwh: Divine Justice and Mercy in Genesis 18:16-33." *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* (vol. 66). 40-41.

"It is a consistent aspect of the biblical portrayal of the relationship between God and human beings that human response is crucial. Genesis 19:29 affirms that Abraham has genuinely been made party to Yhwh's decisions and may have a role in shaping them. The tragedy is that, in comparison with the intercessions of other biblical prophets, Abraham's for Sodom and Gomorrah might have saved the cities had he asked for mercy. The irony is that Abraham gains what he requests: the righteous are not treated as the wicked."

MacDonald, Nathan (2004). "Listening to Abraham, Listening to Yhwh: Divine Justice and Mercy in Genesis 18:16-33." *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* (vol. 66). 41.

Avraham Pleads for Sodom



Avraham Pleads for Sodom. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How does this passage show us that Sodom and Gomorrah are emblematic of violence and injustice?